

Twelve Angry Men and the Creation of a Genre



- 1 In a country of laws, it's not surprising that Americans have an innate fascination with court proceedings. That fascination can be traced back to the very beginnings of our nation.
- 5 Early in our history, news of trials were widely read by Americans. By the first half of the 20th century, some cases became so popular that the phrase "*trial of the century*" was often used. For example, Leon Czolgosz's trial for the assassination of President William McKinley in 1901[...] was all labeled as such and followed closely by nearly every American citizen and people around the
- 10 world. The advent of radio and, later, television only fueled Americans' interest in court procedurals. But, it was in 1954 that writer Reginald Rose emerged as the father of the "**courtroom drama**."

Rose served in the army during World War II from 1942 to 1946, and, once back in civilian life, worked for the CBS network writing teleplays that explored

15 social issues [...]. While working for CBS, Rose was called to jury duty and placed on a panel for a manslaughter case. Of the experience, Rose said in a 1997 interview with *The Daily News*, "*It was such an impressive, solemn setting in a great big wood-paneled courtroom, with a silver-haired judge. We got into this terrific, furious, eight-hour argument in the jury room. I was writing one-hour dramas for*

20 *Studio One in Hollywood, and I thought, 'Wow, what a setting for a drama!'*"

Rose wrote *Twelve Angry Men* for Studio One in 1954, and the piece was originally broadcast as a television play. A year later, Rose adapted the teleplay for the stage and, in 1957, wrote the screenplay for the film adaptation with Henry Fonda playing Juror Eight. Fonda's performance and the film both became

25 a cultural phenomenon.

Twelve Angry Men was revolutionary in that it dared to explore a moral dilemma. Are our opinions and beliefs predisposed by race and social class? [...]